National Qualifications 2026

# X827/75/11

# ESOL
# Listening transcript

FRIDAY, 29 MAY

10:40 AM – 11:15 AM (approx)

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**Instructions to reader(s):**

**Recording 1**

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

Where special arrangements have been agreed in advance to allow the reading of the material, it should be read by two male and one female speakers or two female and one male speakers. Sections marked **(t)** should be read by the teacher.

**(t)** **Recording 1. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 1 before the recording begins.**

(*1 minute pause*)

**TONE**

**Interviewer** Good morning, everyone! Today, we're exploring the fascinating world of cold water therapy. With us is Susan Kerr, a sports instructor, and Tom McLean, a personal trainer with doubts about the benefits of cold water treatments. Welcome . . .

**Susan** Good morning! It's great to be here.

**Tom** Good morning!

**Interviewer** Let's start with you, Susan. Can you explain what cold water therapy is and why it's beneficial?

**Susan** Absolutely! Cold water therapy involves moving between a sauna and a bath filled with ice-cold water. The idea is to stimulate your body, improve circulation, and promote recovery. As someone who used to struggle with sleep, I now regularly get 8 hours. Studies have shown that cold water therapy may also help reduce physical discomfort and could even decrease stress levels.

**Tom** Quite honestly, I don't see any reason to make yourself cold and uncomfortable just for the sake of it.

**Susan** That's a fair point, Tom. I understand why some people might feel that way. The initial shock of cold water can be intense, but it teaches you mental strength. When you consciously choose to stay in cold water, you're also training your mind to handle unpleasantness. And, people have been bathing in cold water for centuries!

**Tom** But does that actually translate to any real benefits? I mean, why should I put myself through that when I could just relax in a warm bath? Cold water therapy is just a trend. I've seen many health fads and fashions come and go. How do we know this is different?

**Interviewer** Well Susan, what evidence do you have to support the effectiveness of cold water therapy?

**Susan** Many studies highlight the positive aspects of cold water immersion, including reduced blood pressure and improved heart function. Famous athletes often post videos about using ice baths for recovery after intense workouts. This type of therapy is even becoming popular with people in their eighties and nineties. Some people have said that they feel a surge of energy and happiness after these sessions, while others have claimed it's even helped them improve their memory, although there haven't been any studies into that as yet.

**Tom** But what about the risks? Isn't there a chance of shock from cold water exposure?

**Susan** Of course, safety is key! I run cold water therapy sessions at Loch Lomond which offer participants a controlled environment to get used to the temperature and teach them how to listen to their bodies. We start with shorter durations in the cold water and gradually increase them. As long as you follow the guidelines, the risks are minimal. There are experts there to guide you, so we've not had anyone experience any problems yet . . .

**Tom** I see your point, but do you really think everyone can benefit from this? Some people might have health issues that make exposure to the cold risky.

**Susan** You're absolutely right, Tom. Not everyone should try cold water therapy. Those with heart problems and those on some types of medication should avoid it. It's always best to consult a healthcare professional before diving into the cold water. For many, however, it can be a transformative experience.

**Interviewer** So, there's a balance to be struck. Tom, now you've got a bit more information, would you consider trying it?

**Tom** I get what Susan is saying, but I'm still not convinced. Maybe I'll give it a try in the future — if I can find a warm place to run to later . . .

**Susan** That's what I like to hear! Just remember, it's all about personal growth and accepting the elements.

**Interviewer** Thank you both for this enlightening discussion. Cold water therapy might not be for everyone, but it's certainly worth a try . . . (*fade out*)

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

**TONE**

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

**TONE**

**[Turn over**

**Instructions to reader(s):**

**Recording 2**

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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**(t)** **Recording 2. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 2 before the recording begins.**

(*1 minute pause*)

**TONE**

**Natalie** Good evening to you all. My name is Natalie, and I'm the owner of the Pirate's Hook Gallery. Well, tonight our guest speaker is George Rogan, a man who may be very familiar to many of you as a long-term resident and local businessman. He has become an internet sensation and, despite only recently having turned to art, his paintings of whales and other marine life are selling all over the world. He is here to talk to you tonight about his rapid rise to fame. I leave you in the capable hands of George Rogan.

**George** Thanks, Natalie, and thanks for inviting me to the Pirate's Hook Gallery! Well, some of you may remember that when I was young my father used to have a painting and decorating business in Cornwall, The Finishing Touch. When I was old enough, I used to help him sand down walls and paint doors. That story followed a logical path and eventually I joined my father in the business, taking over when he retired. But, I began to feel that I didn't have much free time in my life. So, a couple of years ago I stopped working full-time as a decorator and finally had the time to try other things. I've always loved collecting old artworks and antique frames so perhaps it's not surprising that painting now has a much bigger place in my life.

Many people ask me if there is a reason why I have chosen to paint whales. I can't really explain what motivates me — I certainly wasn't expecting to make a living from it. However, just before I began to paint whales, there was one day when I was on holiday with my grandson — I remember browsing in some charity shops looking for frames. I came across an intriguing watercolour painting of whaling ships and whales in the water. It really was striking, and this image led me to try my hand at painting them. I can't even remember the first one I painted, or why, I just liked the imagery and enjoyed doing it. Another question I get asked is how often I paint. Well, I paint every day now that I am no longer running The Finishing Touch. I've decided to move on.

I feel that I have a very good relationship with Natalie at the Pirate's Hook Gallery. The staff there have done a lot to support my work, but our first meeting last year was totally by chance. I had put some of my whale pictures on to a social networking site and Natalie spotted them there. She had a new gallery here in Cornwall, and she tells me she wasn't scouting for artists, but she happened to

notice that my whale pictures were in her local area. She sent me a message and a few days later she dropped into my studio to introduce herself. She took a selection of whale paintings away with her to the gallery, but the first collection sold out almost immediately. Then the second. Then the third. At that point Natalie started putting the prices up to try and slow down sales because I just couldn't keep up with demand!

I'm not able to explain what has made so many people want one of my whale paintings. No one could be more amazed than I am. However, I can tell you some of the comments that buyers have made to me. One elderly buyer said that the paintings simply captured his imagination and reminded him of childhood stories. Someone else said that while the paintings are traditional, they are also fun with a childlike innocence to them and a broad appeal. A comment made by a celebrity that really touched me was that she found the paintings 'quite simply magical'.

I don't consider myself an artist and wouldn't describe myself as one because I've had no formal training at all. It's strange how your life can take such an unexpected turn, but I am thoroughly enjoying my new life and have no plans to go back to decorating.

Well, that's my story and I hope you have found it interesting! And now, if you have any questions . . . (*fade out*)

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

**TONE**

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

**TONE**

**[Turn over**

**Instructions to reader(s):**

**Recording 3**

The talk below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the talk a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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**(t)** **Recording 3. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 3 before the recording begins.**

(*1 minute pause*)

**TONE**

**Presenter** . . . And on today's show we're discussing a new app that is causing controversy in schools. With me are Derek Hawkins, teacher of economics at Broadwood High School, and Karoline Alberts, director of DigiTest, who develop educational apps. So, Derek, could you begin by giving us some background to this story?

**Derek** Morning, yes, so what's happened is that parents at my school were approached to be part of a trial of a new mobile phone application. Not for the usual purposes like messaging staff or checking if their kids are coming back for lunch though . . . this one gives them immediate access to their children's grades every time they sit a test, whether the pupils like it or not. The app also automatically copies in the headteacher, who had no objections about agreeing to the app trial.

**Presenter** Interesting. And I understand that you and some colleagues discovered that this wasn't necessarily a good thing for the pupils?

**Derek** Exactly. It started with me noticing that some pupils appeared more worried in class than usual. I teach Economics myself but, when I casually mentioned this in the staffroom, the Maths and Geography teachers also raised similar concerns. Apart from the sports staff, pretty much all the subject teachers gradually had the same issue. The common denominator? The new app that had only been introduced 3 weeks earlier . . .

**Presenter** So how did you measure this to see if there was a real link between pupil stress levels and the app?

**Derek** Well, I surveyed 500 pupils, and I discovered that the kids whose parents were not constantly checking the app reported a much lower stress level than those who were regular users. People think that schools put too much pressure on their children, but that's not true — these days the weight of expectation usually comes from parents. And, pressure for students to achieve is really a modern thing in my opinion. When I was at school, it was less stressful — parents only met with teachers a few times a year.

**Presenter** Right, but now this app means parents can get a push notification on their phones about their children's results. Isn't that a helpful development, to keep everyone informed?

**Derek** Helpful is the last thing it is. It's appalling. I'm not surprised the frequency of sick days was growing or that the excuses were becoming more creative. Who would want that kind of pressure every day? What we did next was speak to the headteacher, and with her agreement we blocked parents accessing the grades on the app. Pupils' moods instantly lifted — they can see that we did this because we are trying to let them be more independent and take ownership of their own learning.

**Presenter** And how did that go down with the parents? I imagine there was an angry gang at the school gate the next day and many parents emailing in to say how unhappy they were?

**Derek** Well, there were the odd one or two in that position, but the overwhelming majority of them agreed with our decision.

**Presenter** That brings me to Karoline Alberts, director of DigiTest, the company responsible for the app that's been hitting the headlines. Karoline, why do we need this app? Can't kids be trusted just to talk to their parents about what grades they got?

**Karoline** We're not suggesting this app replaces conversation. Actually, our study shows it is more likely to kickstart dialogue between children and adults. It also allows the opportunity for parental involvement, such as additional help with homework, if they can regularly see how their children are performing.

**Presenter** Some people would argue that making mistakes is part of learning, and kids should be able to do that without every mistake or poor grade being analysed, especially by their parents. What would you say to that?

**Karoline** I'd say that parents want to feel connected to the everyday learning and tests their children are doing. Messages about school events all come home via phone apps, so why not grades as well? You could argue that sending photos of a school trip to parents via an app is invading children's privacy, but nobody does. We're providing a service that parents want in this digital age.

**Presenter** I see. Well, what did the pupils have to say about the app? We'll find out after this quick break for the latest news where you are . . . (*fade out*)

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

**TONE**

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

**TONE**

**(t)** **You now have one minute to check your answers.**

(*1 minute pause*)

**(t)** **This is the end of the listening test.**

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